

and Windows. Being free, the community edition of OpenERP offers an excellent opportunity for SMBs to avail the benefits of such a package without incurring the massive investment of their commercial counterparts. OpenERP offers different modules such as logistics, human resources management and finance to customise the installation to suit various enterprises. Demos of installations of OpenERP modified to different enterprises such as bookstores, CRM (call centres), auction house and manufacturing plants are available on the web site. A sampling of the services industry demo showed the depth of the application. With extensive recording and reporting capabilities, the application makes it easy to track every aspect of a business, and offers a bird's eye view of the organisation. Needless to say, using an ERP requires some training and the interface with its many menus and submenus can be bewildering for the novice.

The OpenERP application is available in binary form for Windows and as source code for Linux. OpenERP offers different editions of the application, with the only difference between editions being the level of support provided.

2.8.2 Accounting

Gnucash (www.gnucash.org) is high on public awareness, so we shall not wax eloquent about it. Rather we shall look at the category of web based open source accounting applications. Being web-based they need to be installed on a web server, but the benefit of being able to access one's accounts from any pc (if the webserver is online) is the upside.

Phreebooks (<http://www.phreebooks.com>)

The reason we choose this application is because it is the only one with decent features that offered a demo precluding the need to go through the web installation process. Phreebooks is written in PHP and Javascript and uses MySQL in the backend. The demo succeeds in presenting the full depth of the application. All aspects of biz accounting namely inventory, general ledger, banking and customer are covered in the interface, though it would take a pro to pass the final judgement about its applicability in a production environment.

Another online accounting solution that has an extensive feature list (but not a demo) is LedgerSMB (ledgersmb.org).